FALLEN EMPIRES

The Soda That Beat Coca-Cola: the one-page guide

Three local sodas beat Coca-Cola at home. Coke answered in three different ways. Figures below are as reported by the sources listed at the end; where sources disagree, we say so.

The deal sheet Inca Kola (Peru): Coke partnered

- 1910: the Lindley family opens a bottler in Lima's Rímac district.
- 1935: Inca Kola launches for Lima's 400th anniversary.
- 1970: 38% of the Peruvian market.
- 1995: Inca Kola 32.9% vs Coca-Cola 32%.
- 1999: Coca-Cola takes half of Inca Kola Perú and a fifth of Lindley. Price never officially disclosed (reports range from about $200M to $300M). Coca-Cola owns the trademark outside Peru.
- 2005: Lindley buys two thirds of Embotelladora Latinoamericana for $215M.

Thums Up (India): Coke bought it

- 1977: Coca-Cola leaves India rather than reveal its formula and sell 60% to an Indian partner.
- Ramesh Chauhan (Parle) creates Thums Up.
- 1993: Coke buys Thums Up, Gold Spot and Limca for about $60M (most sources). Thums Up held about 85% of India's cola market (widely repeated, secondary sources).
- 1997: relaunched by Coca-Cola.
- 2021: a billion-dollar brand in India.

Irn-Bru (Scotland): Coke never bought it

- 1889: "Ironbrew" in New York; Barr's sells Iron Brew by 1899; official launch 1901.
- 1948: sold as Irn-Bru.

- Top-selling soft drink in Scotland for over a century; by 2003 sales of the two were roughly equal; third best-selling soft drink in the UK.
- A.G. Barr is still independent and listed in London.
- 2018: sugar cut to under 5g per 100ml ahead of the UK sugar tax.

Three things to notice

1. In all three cases the local brand won on **local taste and local identity**, not on a bigger budget.
2. The global giant's move depended on the situation: a **stake** when the local bottler was struggling (Peru), an **outright purchase** when the local brand dominated (India).
3. Staying independent is possible: Irn-Bru kept its own company, its own formula debates and its own listing.

Two traps when reading brand stories

1. **Market share is not sales growth.** Shares quoted for 1970, 1993 and 1995 are snapshots, not trends.
2. **"Reported" is not "confirmed".** Prices and shares of private deals are often secondary-source numbers. Check the original filings or press when it matters.

Glossary

- **Market share**: the part of all sales in a category that one brand makes.
- **Trademark**: the legal right to a brand name and logo.
- **Bottler / franchise**: a company licensed to make and sell a drink in a territory.
- **Joint venture**: two companies sharing ownership of a business.
- **Acquisition**: one company buying another or its brands.

Sources

- Wikipedia: Inca Kola, Irn-Bru, Thums Up, A.G. Barr, with their references
- Daily Pioneer (2013): Ramesh Chauhan profile; Business Today (2022): Thums Up story

- ThePrint: Thums Up and Coca-Cola
- NPR (2003): Scotland's other national drink
- The Grocer (2010): Irn-Bru in England and Wales

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